

findings of a joint survey of the disputed border area. In addition to the drinking water row, protesters also claim that the Tamil Nadu Government has encroached approximately 400 acre of land in Karnataka to promote tourism, a charge that the state denies.

The agitating organisations like Hogenakkal Jalapatha Ulisi Samiti are also planning to file a public interest litigation questioning the decision of the Tamil Nadu Government of taking up the project even when the issue of sharing Cauvery waters was pending in the Supreme Court. Samiti chief Puttaraje Urs blames the Karnataka government for ignoring the area in the past using

Tripathi claims that the state had agreed to the Bangalore water scheme and Karnataka had reciprocated with its nod for the Hogenakkal scheme in 1998 and only on this basis had the Centre given a "no objection" to the water project which Karnataka is now objecting to. Karnataka's Chief Secretary Sudhakar Rao, in his letter to the Union Water Resource Secretary Umesh Narayan Panjiar, says the Hogenakkal project was "undoubtedly" a new scheme. "Until the interstate implications arising from the project are examined under the provisions of the interstate Water Disputes Act, 1956, the Government of Tamil

project, the Bangalore water project, taken up for the utilisation of 30,000 million cubic feet, was part of the state's claim before the CWDI."

Political parties in both the states are now pressing the Centre to step in and keep the controversy from boiling over. In the ongoing saga of protests, Madras High Court lawyers attacked Hotel Sangeetha, run by Kannadigas. In a tit-for-tat reaction Kannada groups deflated a Tamil Nadu bus near Maddur in Mandya district. The Tamil film world is hoping that Rajnikanth and Prakash

IN DISPUTE: Karunanidhi (left); a protester tearing the poster of a Tamil film in Bangalore

SIPRA DAS



PTI PHOTO

"Karnataka is playing a double game in water issues with us."

M. KARUNANIDHI, CHIEF MINISTER, TAMIL NADU

the Veerappan menace as an alibi.

When the Hogenakkal joint water scheme ran into controversy, no one thought this would become an emotional issue. The Tamil Nadu Assembly has adopted a resolution urging the Centre to come forward to safeguard the rights of the people of its state. "Even if they chop off our legs and hands, we will make sure that the project is completed," says Karunanidhi. His Government has enough points to show that "Karnataka is playing a double game in these issues with Tamil Nadu".

Tamil Nadu's Chief Secretary L.K.

Nadu is not within its right to take up the project." On the other hand, Rao says the grant of no-objection by the Union Water Resources Ministry could not be considered as a resolution of interstate implications arising from the project under consideration. The Tamil Nadu Government had not made the project a part of its complaint or statement of case before the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal (CWDI). The Tamil Nadu Government could not take up the new project without disclosing the detailed project report and other relevant information to Karnataka. Rao says, "Unlike the Hogenakkal

Raj, both imports from Karnataka but stars in Tamil Nadu, will join a planned protest fast. The Vedike have threatened to cut off rail and road transport between the two states and close down trade establishments owned by people belonging to Tamil Nadu.

With Karnataka slated to go for polls in May 2008, political parties hope that the issue will be sidelined. But for small time Kannada groups that are trying to carve a political space for themselves, the smoke and the rock generated by the Hogenakkal controversy could not have come at a better time.

with bureau inputs